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A lo-fi article

to relax/study

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he rise of Lo-fi music's role in pop culture is quite amusing, considering "lo-fi" refers to

low fidelity music, consisting of undesired traits in a soundtrack, like vinyl fuzz, misplayed notes and distorted noises. The raw nature of lo-fi music accompanied with jazzy and acoustic elements blended with electronic music evokes a warm, nostalgic feeling among its listeners. The inherently tranquil aesthetic captivates fans of various other genres of music, from metal to hip hop.

60S / DIY GARAGE ROCK

Lo-fi music can be traced back to the emerging DIY scene in rock and roll in the 1960s. As music production became more accessible, young people worldwide were motivated to record their music. This marks the origins of characteristic distortion, fuzziness, and tape skip sounds widely used today in lo-fi music. The punk and garage rock bands were the precursors to Lo-fi. The Beach Boys home-produced albums *Smiley Smile* (1967) and *Wild Honey* (1967) are regarded as early forms of lo-fi. R. Stevie Moore went solo in the late 1960s and began recording full-length albums on reel-to-reel tape in his parents' Tennessee basement. He was the first to call attention to the aesthetics of the home recording process, which had a unique charm of its own.

To Listen:

- Beach Boys - *Smiley Smile*



Samurai Champloo, an icon for modern lo-fi

80S / ALT ROCK

The emergence of the sub-genres of alt-rock, dreampop and shoegaze significantly influenced lo-fi music. Shoegaze is distinguished by its ethereal blend of masked vocals, guitar distortion and effects, feedback, and excessive loudness. Fuzz and distortion are at the heart of Shoegaze music. It's thick, expansive, and foggy, with the voices blending seamlessly with the instruments, producing a rich soundscape. Dreampop is defined by its emphasis on mood and aural texture with equal focus on pop melody. Dreampop has aspects that are more akin to pop music. It's not as foggy or distorted as shoegaze, but the ethereal voice stands out against the instruments. These characteristics of dreampop and shoegaze paved the way for the slow, reverb-heavy dreamy aesthetic of modern lo-fi music. The Scottish band Cocteau Twins has been at the helm of making dreampop music mainstream, ushering in the dreamlike quality of Lo-fi.

To Listen:

- Cocteau Twins - *Lorelei*
- Dean Wareham - *The Dancer Disappears*

90S / HIP HOP

Lo-fi combines elements from hip-hop, particularly boom-bap. Drum loops are made up of bass, and snare drums are referred to as boom-bap. Hip-hop production like this was popular in the 1990s, especially on the East Coast. Nas, Wu-Tang Clan and A Tribe Called Quest are among well-known boom-bap musicians. Wu-Tang Clan's album *36 Chambers*, released in 1993, encompasses many characteristics seen in lo-fi hip-hop today, with its dirty, gritty and raw aesthetic blended well with their extraordinary style of sampling audio clips from old movies and tv shows. They had a significant impact on hip-hop and may have paved the way for lo-fi hip-hop today. Modern lo-fi hip-hop emulates Wu-Tang Clan's sampling style and technique, reusing sounds to create new songs. The majority of the samples are audio snippets from vintage TV episodes, movies, and, most notably, anime.

However, when it comes to lo-fi hip-hop, Nujabes and J Dilla are regarded as the genre's progenitors. Nujabes' music is less concerned with genre and more concerned with emotion. Nujabes created a distinct sound